



FEAST: Cuisine went global with a vengeance

THOUGHTS

Rising income and wealth inequalities, if not matched by a rise of incomes across the nation, can lead to social unrest.

MANMOHAN SINGH,
PRIME MINISTER

He is the centre of his universe. The parents are paranoid about him coming to any harm, so they protect him with all they have and give him all he wants.

(on single child)



PRAHALAD KAKAR,
AD FILMMAKER

The luxury market is only one chapter in the India story of rising affluence. Like elsewhere, the Wealth Effect also creates the Snob Effect. Indians now think nothing of spending Rs 15 lakh on a unique mobile phone number, while helicopter and small aircraft companies are busy selling planes to Indians for whom time has become big money and even flying First Class is not exclusive enough. In fact, even rural India was determined not to be left behind in the flight of conspicuous consumption. Rustic they may have been in dress and demeanor but not in flash. Farmers in north India, flush with money from land sold to developers, were increasingly swapping the traditional horse for a helicopter to fly grooms to the brides' village, happily shelling out Rs 1 lakh an hour for the service. Indeed, much of the conspicuous consumption and the new big spenders were actually located in non-Metro towns. The World Wealth Report by Merrill Lynch put the number of millionaires in India at 93,000, up from 82,000 in 2005-06, and said that India recorded the world's

second fastest growth at 19.3 per cent in the number of high networth individuals.

The affluent Indian has never been studied as closely and the results were revealing. One study estimated the market potential of the 15-35 year bracket at \$14 billion (Rs 55,181 crore) and growing at 20 per cent annually, while another survey showed that it was the 50-pluses, India's baby boomers, who were emerging as the new big spenders, having got their children's marriages out of the way and now splurging on themselves.

Affluence, inevitably, has its negative side, namely excess and self-indulgence and also indulgent parents, who spoil teenagers not only for choice but also plain spoilt. Alistair Pereira, the Mumbai teenager who mowed down 15 people while driving drunk, was one tragic case, Adnan Patrawala was another. The teenage son of a Mumbai businessman drove off to meet friends he met online. He called to tell his parents he would not be coming home at night and was found dead later, killed by three youngsters barely in their